

Skill Tracker – Market Research

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1. Aggregate Findings

Findings: We Brainstormed ideas across many different topics ranging from medicine, education, recreational activities, exploration, budgeting, business, video gaming, and many others. As we narrowed down based on our preferences and the potential we saw, we selected five core ideas: a Budget Simulation, Recreational Activity Tracker, Item Holder, Picture Exploration, and Planning and Scheduling concept. Each idea started from a general problem or opportunity that we thought could be useful to people, whether that meant improving something that already existed, adding features to an existing type of application, or creating a new way to engage users.

After we developed the main ideas for each concept, we began to interview people to get a better understanding of whether these problems existed and how people currently experienced and handled these problems. The interviews helped us find which ideas really connected to people's experiences and see which ideas could be useful if a solution was found. After comparing the results from the different ideas and the feedback from our interviews, the Recreational Activity Tracker and Budget Simulation stood out as the two concepts that generated the most useful discussion and potential for further development.

Eventually, the one that showed different but useful patterns was the recreational activity tracker interview. People often discovered new activities through friends, social media, or other forms of online content, while continuing an activity depended on factors such as time, motivation, and personal circumstances. When it came to the tracking feature, the interviews suggested that people did not necessarily want a highly rigid system. Instead, they often recognized their progress through personal milestones, completed projects, photos, or simply remembering what they had accomplished. The research also showed that other people could influence participation, including friends, groups, and communities.

We began to come up with different features that could help users discover, organize, and track their recreational activities while also giving them ways to recognize their progress. We also explored different ways this new platform could bring income without relying only on the basic tracking feature. One of our main ideas was to allow instructors or users to create and offer classes related to different activities. Another was to provide users with the ability to pay for access to courses or certifications offered through different institutions. This all led to the first

big change in the initial vision we had for this last idea we decided to expand upon. Hence, we realize that the culmination of ideas we had gather for this project became something more than a simple tracker and we decided to finally give a name and a purpose to said platform and we came up with SkillUp a personalized skill-development platform designed to make learning more accessible, organized, engaging, and rewarding.

2. Top Pick: Deep Dive

Across both phases of interviews focused on recreational activities and skill development, the same set of struggles kept surfacing: people have trouble finding the right way to start a new activity, staying motivated once life gets busy, recognizing their own progress, and keeping any record of what they've actually accomplished. These four roadblocks, more than any single complaint, are what convinced us SkillUp, an app built around personalized learning journeys and achievement portfolios, was the right call.

Getting started is harder than it looks, due to several participants pointing to the starting phase itself as the biggest barrier, not a lack of interest. One participant said the volume of information online made it hard to "siphon through the right information" to find what they needed. Another person said they lose interest when an activity has too many setup steps before reaching "the fun stuff." A third pointed to cost and material barriers, needing to buy supplies like canvas and paint before they could even try painting. A fourth described feeling embarrassed to be a beginner and unsure whether a paid beginner class was worth it just to "test the waters." These are different forms of the same problem, people want a lower friction on ramp into a new activity.

Progress is hard to see while you're in it is a recurring theme that participants don't track progress formally but importantly, this wasn't always framed as a problem they wanted solved. Several described progress as something they only notice in hindsight. One participant called it a "lagging indicator," noticing changes in strength or how clothes fit only after weeks of consistency, without any real-time system to show the actual progression happening. Another said, "sometimes you don't see it until you are done with it," and described stopping to reflect as their own informal method of recognizing what they'd accomplished. This suggests the opportunity isn't necessarily "add a tracker where none exists" some participants already have informal ways of noticing progress (comparing current work to past work, remembering if something felt faster this time). The gap is more that these methods are inconsistent and easy to lose track of, not that people have literally no way of understanding their own growth.

Motivation is also about social, not just personal, several participants directly credited another person with keeping them consistent a workout partner who "helps maintain their consistency," a sibling they joined on a weight-loss journey, co-workers who eventually got them into golf, friends whose "encouragement has consistently kept them motivated." On the flip side,

participants also described losing motivation when a community fell apart. For example, when a weekly organizer in the community has relocated. Another example from our interviews, when competition made an activity stop feeling fun, where an interviewee felt that the sport became too competitive, however, came back when they found a less competitive environment. It points toward SkillUp including some kind of community or accountability layer, not just a personal log.

People keep informal records just not ones built for this. A few participants already had some version of a record system in place, writing achievements and goals in a notebook and checking back on it, keeping a running playlist of songs learned on guitar, or simply pointing to a finished piece, such as a painting or a completed cosplay that took six months, as the record of the activity itself. It would be an overstatement to say these participants have no system what they don't have is anything that keeps that record accessible, connects it across different activities, or makes it easy to look back on.

Where reminders and scheduling fit, one participant, describing a time they stopped attending dance classes as a beginner, specifically suggested a system that could recognize they were new to an activity, remind them roughly 30 minutes before a scheduled session, and follow up if they didn't show something they compared to an "accountability coach." That response, along with the broader pattern of people losing momentum once responsibilities like work or school took over, is what pointed us toward exploring reminders and scheduling as a feature. We're treating this as a direction worth building toward rather than a confirmed fix, one participant's proposed solution isn't the same as evidence that reminders alone solve the consistency problem, and we don't have interview data showing that a reminder would have kept these participants engaged.

Taken together, this research is what shaped SkillUp's two core pillars, a personalized learning journey that meets people where they are when starting something new, rather than assuming a single onboarding path works for every activity, and an achievement portfolio that gives structure to the achievements, milestones, and informal records participants are already keeping in scattered places such as notebooks, playlists, phone galleries, finished projects, without asking them to adopt an entirely new habit from scratch.

3. What Didn't Work / What You Pivoted From

During our initial research phase, our team explored several project ideas such as Budget Simulation, Picture Exploration, Item Holder, Planning and Scheduling with Forceful Pictures and Recreational Activity Tracker. Through interviews and team discussions we analyzed the problems each project could resolve and development challenges.

1. Budget Simulation

Budget Simulation was our team's second choice. The concept focused on helping individuals evaluate purchases and predict purchase effects to make better financial decisions.

Our interviews showed that participants had challenges related to budgeting, unexpected expenses, and determining if purchases were affordable. However, the responses did not give us a clear direction for creating a solution that could solve these problems.

After discussing potential functionality, we decided to go with SkillUp instead. Although Budget Simulation would target an existing problem, we were missing a clear direction on how to provide a solution.

2. Picture Exploration

Our Picture Exploration project focused on helping users update and view recent images for locations they might want to explore. During our interview we found that most participants were already able to find recent information about places just by using Google.

Even though some participants did find some outdated or inaccurate information, most were able to find the information through other services. Our research showed that there is no significant problem that requires a new platform from where to find updated information. As a result, we decided to abandon Picture Exploration.

3. Item Holder

Our Item Holder concept focused on providing a service that would allow individuals to reserve items they were interested in purchasing but could not immediately afford and obtain. Our interviews gave us useful insights into purchasing decisions and provided potential services that could help in these situations.

After we evaluated the concept, we determined that there were significant financial and operation risks with potential fraudulent transactions, scams, and financial losses with reserving and holding items. Although the research found potential opportunities, we decided to abandon Item Holder due to financial risks.

4. Planning and Scheduling with Forceful Pictures

Our Planning and Scheduling with Forceful Pictures concept focused on helping individuals improve their time management and be accountable for completing their scheduled activities.

After evaluating the concept and reviewing the interviews, we noticed that requiring users to provide photo evidence could become frustrating and inconvenient instead of

encouraging. Our interviews also did not show a need for the system we wanted to work with. There was also no business potential and as a result we decided to abandon this idea.

5. Pivots in our Recreational Activity Tracker

Our original concept focused on providing users with a place to record recreational activities and personal accomplishments, such as books they read, recipes cooked or progress on any recreational activity.

Throughout interviews and discussions, we expanded the concept to include learning resources, instructor feedback, skill recognition, and opportunities to share with friends.

We also reconsidered our original competitive approach after learning that some individuals preferred enjoying recreational activities without the pressure of comparing themselves to others. Instead, we focused on personalized progress tracking, individual achievements, and community support.